having it buried ‘in the same place . . . [as] the infidels of Hindustan who are the creatures of the king’s bounties and favours’.[71]

Akbar had already lost so many friends and advisers, he was loath to lose another. He did not hold Aziz’s outburst and departure against him, only wrote to his milk brother ‘reproaching him for distressing his mother [Jiji Anaka] and himself by going off without leave and exposing his family to the dangers of the ocean’.[72] The emperor was sure that Aziz would be back soon; and sure enough, his friend returned in 1594. It was an emotional reunion. ‘From exceeding love, tears fell from [Akbar’s] eyes,’ writes Abul Fazl. As for Aziz, he’d had a terrible time in Mecca, so much so that he gave up all thought of his beard and joined Akbar’s circle of disciples.

It took him twenty years – ever since Aziz first condemned Akbar’s mansabdari reforms – but the emperor had managed to win his friend over.

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In the Deccan, meanwhile, dissension grew increasingly rife. Murad had only just reached the empire’s southern borders, in 1595, when rumours of his ‘hauteur’[73] began to drift to Akbar in Lahore. The prince was meant to work with Abdur Rahim, Bairam’s orphaned son, now an accomplished general, who had so distinguished himself in Gujarat a decade ago that he had been given his father’s old rank and made khan-khanan in 1584. Perhaps Murad resented the favour that Akbar showed Abdur Rahim, or perhaps he just didn’t like him – and ‘tale-bearers and interested persons’, of whom there was no lack in the Mughal ranks, ‘widened the breach’.[74]

Murad showed no interest in working with the vastly more experienced amir. Abdur Rahim had to race after the prince when Murad decided to march upon Ahmednagar without waiting for him; and even then, Murad wouldn’t meet him. ‘[D]isgusted’, Abdur Rahim went on strike.[75]

Somehow, in the winter of 1596, the squabbling Mughals managed to besiege Ahmednagar, guarded by its redoubtable queen, Chand Bibi. The siege, writes Abul Fazl, was ‘a tedious affair’. For once, the historian is guilty of understatement. The Mughals’ onslaught was an embarrassment. After two months of a listless siege, in February 1596, Murad’s men managed to make a breach in the fort walls – and then, remembering what had happened with the delayed second fuse in Chittorgarh, refused to